

Chapter 13: Insights and Reflections

Writing up to this point, the primary research content has all concluded; this has truly been a protracted journey that constantly mobilized my emotions. Although I might be ridiculed by readers for saying this—after all, my own academic major was hardly studied outstandingly—I still wish to say, from the perspective of a mathematics student, that after completing the sorting of human history, particularly the history of the **classical period** (古典时代) and the **Middle Ages** (中世纪), what gives me confidence in my conclusions is not merely the comprehensiveness of my investigation and the scientific nature of my methods, but also the "beauty" of the results.

Now we behold a brand-new, unified panorama of human societal development. We do not deny the existence of pluralism; in fact, we have indeed observed that the historical processes experienced by different regions and different ethnic groups exhibit obvious differences. These differences, together with the characteristics of physical geography, have created the rich and colorful cultures of the human world. We can even generously admit that these differences are beneficial to humanity as a whole, rather than merely causing tragic consequences in many places.

Just imagine, what would happen if human civilizations in all parts of the world started at the same time and developed at the same speed? Then they would inevitably experience a glorious **classical period** together, and then march toward **feudalization** (封建化) together. If the **feudalization** process occurred globally at the same time, then many achievements of classical civilization would indeed be destroyed and forgotten during a phase of social dissolution; this, of course, would be highly regrettable. At the same time, it would also be much slower for humanity to progress toward modern civilization through the social reconstruction [社会重构] of the **Middle Ages**.

In realistic history, when the Western Roman Empire (西罗马帝国) collapsed amidst **feudalization**, the **classical empires** (古典帝国) in the **Middle East** (中东) stubbornly survived for several centuries in various forms. They indeed did a great deal of work in protecting, inheriting, and reflecting the achievements of Western classical civilization, ultimately enabling feudal Europe [封建欧洲] to benefit during its process of revival.

Japan is identical; although China's **bureaucratic restoration** [官僚复辟] was obviously disastrous for China itself, the still-prosperous economy and culture of China during the Tang and Song periods [唐宋时期] naturally served as a driving force for Japan's development. If China had **feudalized** normally, then large-scale exchanges between Japan and China would likely have been postponed until at least the tenth century, that is, waiting until China itself entered the **High Middle Ages** (中世纪盛期) before occurring. Would Japan still have been able to develop relatively independently into the developed country it is today? I am afraid it is quite unlikely. Judging by the backwardness of Japanese civilization's starting point relative to China, although it might not necessarily have been conquered by a Chinese feudal regime [封建政权], it absolutely could not have achieved its international and historical status in **Our timeline** (本位面).

Therefore, even if I never let slip a single opportunity to mock and critique the Byzantine (拜占庭) rulers, let alone the despotic rulers of China during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期), I still dare not assert that these various countries that deviated from the general developmental process of human society—namely, the **historical sequence** (历史序列)—failed to generate any beneficial impacts.

What we must emphasize is that, during the transition from a *classical society* (古典社会) to a *feudal society* (封建社会), there was indeed a possibility of technological and cultural regression due to the rise of the *natural economy* (自然经济) and urban decline, because they could no longer be passed down without patrons and arenas to utilize them. Just like Goryeo (高丽) celadon, everyone now knows that the porcelain level of the Joseon Dynasty (朝鲜李朝) was even inferior to that of the Goryeo period; did the Koreans become stupid? Not at all, the times merely changed. The astonishing progress China achieved in metal smelting during the *classical period* was originally largely forged by centralized, state-run production; if China had genuinely *feudalized*, then the level and scale of metal smelting would definitely have had a very high probability of regressing during the early stage of *feudalization* [封建化早期]. It is not difficult to imagine that, consequently, the technology and culture neighboring countries could learn would have been reduced.

The current Western countries of Europe and America, as well as Japan, should indeed feel proud of their miraculous success, yet they identically should not forget the contributions made to their success by those "failed states." Therefore, from the perspective of human historical development, I believe that developed countries indeed bear a greater responsibility toward human society. They should not view the realization and defense of modern civilization solely as their own enterprise, but should rather view it as an enterprise belonging to all of humanity and find ways to shoulder this mission. **Because from an objective perspective, the success of developed countries is the result of the combined action of internal and external factors; the reality is that the failure of some countries leads to the even greater success of others.**

十三，心得和反思

写到这里，主要的研究内容就全部结束了，这真是一段漫长的，时刻调动着我情感的旅途。虽然我这么说可能会被读者嘲笑，毕竟我自己的专业学得也谈不上出色，但是我还是想以一个数学系学生的观点说，当我完成对于人类历史特别是古典时代和中世纪历史的梳理之后，让我对于自己的结论有自信的不只是我考察的全面性和方法的科学性，还有一个原因是结果的“美”。现在我们看到了一个崭新的，人类社会发展的统一图景。我们不否认多元化的存在，实际上我们的确看到了不同地方，不同民族所经历的历史进程具有明显的差异，这种差异和自然地理的特征一起创造了人类世界丰富多彩的文化。我们甚至也可以大方地承认这种差异对于整个人类来说具有益处，而不仅仅是在许多地方造成了悲剧性的后果。试想一下，如果全世界所有地方的人类文明起步在一起，发展速度相同，那会发生什么呢？那么他们必然一起经历一个光辉的古典时代，然后一起走向封建化。如果封建化进程在全世界同一时期发生，那么古典文明的很多成果确实会在一个社会解体的阶段被破坏和遗忘，这当然是很遗憾的。同时人类想要通过中世纪的社会重构走向近现代文明也会慢上许多。在现实的历史中，当西罗马帝国在封建化中崩溃时，中东地区的古典帝国却以各种形式又顽强地生存了几个世纪，它们确实在保护，继承和反映西方古典文明的成果上做出了很多工作，最终使得封建欧洲得以在复兴的过程中受益。日本也是同样的，虽然中国的官僚复辟对于中国自己显然是灾难性的，但是唐宋时期中国仍然繁荣的经济文化对于日本的发展当然起到了推动作用。如果中国正常封建化的话，那么日本与中国的大规模交流可能至少要推迟到十世纪，也就是等到中国自己进入中世纪盛期才会发生。日本还能够相对独立地发展成为现在这样的发达国家吗，恐怕是不太可能的，就以日本文明起步相对于中国的落后来，它虽然未必被某个中国的封建政权征服掉，但是绝对不可能达到本位面的国际地位和历史地位。

因此，哪怕我对于拜占庭统治者从来不放过任何一个嘲讽和批判的机会，更遑论对于复辟官僚时期中国的专制统治者。我也不敢说这些各种各样偏离了一般人类社会的发展进程，即历史序列的国家没有造成任

何有益的影响。我们必须强调的是，在古典社会走向封建社会的过程中因为自然经济兴起和城市衰退的确有很多技术和文化存在退步的可能，因为它们现在因为没有赞助者和用武之地也传承不下去了。就好比高丽的青瓷一样，现在所有人都知道朝鲜李朝的瓷器水平甚至不如高丽时期，难道是朝鲜人变本了吗，并不是，时代变了而已。像中国在古典时期在金属冶炼上取得的惊人的进步，原本在很大程度上就是集中化的官营生产所造就的，如果中国真的封建化了，那么金属冶炼水平和规模在封建化早期在就一定有很大的可能要退步。不难想象，如此周边国家能学到的技术和文化就少了。现在的欧美西方国家和日本的确应该为他们奇迹般的成功感到自豪，却也不应该忘记他们的成功中有哪些“失败国家”的功劳。所以从人类历史发展的观点认为，发达国家对于人类社会的确负有更大的责任，它们不应当把实现和保卫现代文明只视为自己的事业，而应当视其为属于全人类的事业并且想办法担起这个使命。因为从客观角度来说，发达国家的成功是内外因素共同作用的结果，事实就是，一些国家的失败导致一些国家更加成功。